



Enemies and protectors

THE POPULARITY OF THE theater in London attracted hostility from powerful enemies. The Lord Mayor and his aldermen saw any large gathering as a threat to law and order, and were always trying to close the playhouses down. Many city officials were also Puritans, who were against any form of entertainment. Fortunately, the actors had some powerful protectors. They were supported by Queen Elizabeth and her courtiers, who loved to watch plays. The Earl of Essex, the Lord Admiral, and the Lord Chamberlain became patrons of acting companies, which were then named after them.

POWERFUL PATRONS

In 1594, the Lord Chamberlain, Henry Carey (1524–1596), became the patron of Shakespeare's theater company. Carey was the queen's cousin and one of her closest advisors. Being the patron of an acting company was a sign of status and power.

WHIPPED OUT OF TOWN

It was against the law to perform plays without the permission of a powerful noble, and the law said that players caught performing illegally were to be treated as "rogues, vagabonds, and sturdy beggars." They were whipped out of town and branded by being burned through the ear with a hot iron.



Members of the public were used to seeing criminals being punished in the streets

A beggar is whipped out of town

SCANDALOUS!

In 1597, Ben Jonson was put in prison for writing *The Isle of Dogs*, a play said to be "full of scandalous matter." This shows that, despite their noble protectors, acting companies and playwrights could still get into trouble if they put on controversial plays. Jonson's play was banned and never published, so we do not know why the government found it so shocking.

Portrait of Ben Jonson (1572–1637)

POWERLESS PROTEST

The Lord Mayor and his council of aldermen were responsible for law and order in the city of London. The Lord Mayor had no control at all, however, over what went on outside the city walls, where most of the playhouses were built. All that he could do was to send letters to the queen's ministers, the Privy Council, complaining about the dangers of the theater.



Lord Mayor



Aldermen, members of the council



Puritans dressed more simply than other people

ALL WORK AND NO PLAY

Puritans thought that people should spend all of their time in work or prayer. Playhouses, which stopped people from doing both, were under constant attack from Puritan preachers.